



“The modern airplane creates a new geographical dimension... There are no distant places any longer: the world is small and the world is one.”

WENDELL WILLKIE
ONE WORLD (1943)

JET PASSENGER TRAVEL

DURING THE SECOND HALF OF THE 20TH CENTURY AIR TRAVEL BROUGHT EVERY PART OF THE GLOBE WITHIN EASY REACH OF ANY TRAVELER

AT THE START OF THE 1940s, American airline bosses and aircraft manufacturers sensed that passenger air travel was on the brink of a quantum leap forward. The Boeing 307 Stratoliner, with its pressurized cabin and supercharged engines, was already flying above the weather, offering a new level of comfort to passengers. Millionaire aviation enthusiast Howard Hughes had bought into TWA and, with fellow executive Jack Frye, was pushing Lockheed into developing the Constellation, a four-engined airliner capable of transporting people nonstop across the United States. At Douglas, the four-engined DC-4 was almost ready as a successor to the twin-engined DC-3, and a pressurized version, later to become the DC-6, was already under discussion. Then

came the war. After the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941, all production of commercial aircraft was stopped and resources were devoted exclusively to building military aircraft. Before it could enter service as an airliner, the DC-4 became the C-54 transport plane. Work on the Constellation was halted, and then the aircraft was rather tardily ordered by the armed forces as the C-69 transport. Like the manufacturers, the airlines were drafted into war service.

Although in a sense this was an interruption of commercial aviation, the war actually generated a rapid acceleration in the growth already under way. There were important technological advances, chiefly in navigation, radar, and communications, but above all there was a transformation in scale.

DOUGLAS DC-4

Marketed as the “First with Four,” the DC-4 was a four-engine version of the DC-3. It could carry between 50 and 80 passengers and had the range to offer a transatlantic service with a single fuel stop. However, it lacked a pressurized cabin for high-altitude flight. Shown below is the military adaptation, the C-54 Skymaster.

